

Week 16: Apocalyptic Literature

How to Read the Bible — 19-Week Study

"Apocalyptic" is one of the most misunderstood words in the Bible — tonight we'll look at what it actually means.

1. When you hear the word "apocalyptic" or "the apocalypse," what images come to mind? Does that picture come more from the Bible, or from movies and pop culture?
2. **Read Isaiah 6.** What does Isaiah see in this vision, and what does he say the moment he sees it? Why do you think encountering God's holiness undoes Isaiah before it commissions him?
3. Isaiah's vision doesn't just show him the future — it sends him back into his ordinary life with a new assignment. If you were given a sudden, clear glimpse of what's really going on beneath your current circumstances, what part of your life would you most want that perspective on?
4. **Read Daniel 7.** What does Daniel see come up out of the sea, and what is given to "one like a son of man" later in the vision? What does the contrast between the beastly kingdoms and this figure tell you about how God's kingdom is different from the kingdoms of the world?
5. Apocalyptic imagery — the chaotic sea, wild beasts, a throne in the heavens — shows up again and again across the Bible, all the way back to Genesis. Why do you think the biblical authors kept reusing the same pictures instead of inventing new ones each time?
6. **Read Revelation 1.** How does John describe the risen Jesus in this vision, and how does John himself respond to seeing him? This vision follows the exact same pattern as Isaiah's and Daniel's centuries earlier — does it change how you think about Revelation to realize it's less a coded countdown to the future and more an "unveiling" of who's really in charge, right now?

7. Because apocalypse means "unveiling" rather than "catastrophe," how might that change how you'd want to approach reading — or hearing sermons about — the book of Revelation?
8. All three of these visions gave the person who received them comfort or courage to face something hard in their present moment. What's a hard "present moment" in your life where you could use that same kind of heavenly perspective?
9. What's one piece of hope from these passages that you want to carry with you into this week?